



Zelensky rushes to steady U.S. support

Oval Office rift, mercurial Trump snarl leader’s bid to mend fences with ally

BY SIOBHÁN O’GRADY AND KOSTIANTYN KHUDOV

KYIV — One week after Volodymyr Zelensky gambled on a confrontational strategy with President Donald Trump and wound up at the center of an explosive Oval Office meeting, the Ukrainian president is scrambling to restore ties with Washington as the White House ramps up pressure for a quick end to the war with Russia.

On Friday, after Russia launched a massive missile and drone attack against Ukraine, Trump said he would consider imposing new “large-scale” sanctions and tariffs against Moscow until a ceasefire and final agreement were reached.

The rare threat against Russian President Vladimir Putin suggested Zelensky’s outreach might be working. But hours later, Trump appeared to reverse course again, apparently condoning Russian attacks and reiterating his claim that Kyiv’s position was weak.

“I actually think [Putin is] doing what anybody else would do,” Trump told reporters at the White House on Friday afternoon. “He wants to get it ended.” Russia, he repeated, “has all the cards.” Moscow launched more attacks overnight.

Zelensky, who has led Ukraine through more than three years of all-out war with Russia, is now facing one of the most politically

SEE UKRAINE ON A20



EDUARDO SOTERAS/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

A Turkish arms firm helped fuel Sudan’s brutal civil war, documents reveal

BY KATHARINE HOURELD AND ELIZABETH DWOSKIN

A destroyed armored vehicle on a street in Omdurman, Sudan, last June. At least 150,000 people have been killed in the war, which has dragged on for 22 months.

The secret shipment of Turkish drones and missiles had just been delivered to the Sudanese army in September, and a team from Baykar — Turkey’s largest defense company — was on the ground to make sure the deal went smoothly.

Once the drones were in action, a Baykar employee sent a series of messages to his boss.

“Today’s attack,” he messaged on Sept. 12, alongside a video of an airstrike on an unfinished concrete shell of a building. “2nd attack” read his message three days later, as a missile slammed into the front of a large warehouse. In another video he shared, a person walks through the frame seconds

before the explosion.

The remarkable exchange was captured in a trove of text messages and phone intercepts, photos and videos, weapons documents and other financial records provided to The Washington Post and partially authenticated using phone records, trade records and satellite data. The cache reveals in startling new detail how a well-connected Turkish defense firm covertly fueled Sudan’s devastating civil war, which has dragged on for 22 months and created what the United Nations calls the world’s worst humanitarian catastrophe. It also shows how Turkey’s defense industry has built rela-

SEE SUDAN ON A19

NIH reels with fear and uncertainty about future of scientific research

BY CAROLYN Y. JOHNSON AND JOEL ACHENBACH

Inside the National Institutes of Health, there was little doubt about who would be tapped to lead the world’s preeminent biomedical institution through the first weeks of the second Trump administration: Lawrence Tabak.

Tabak is a dentist and a scientist who was the longtime second-

in-command at the sprawling campus in Bethesda, Maryland. Widely respected, he served as NIH acting director for two years under President Joe Biden.

At 10 a.m. on Jan. 24, Tabak sent a staffwide email. The Trump administration had installed Matthew Memoli, a longtime NIH influenza researcher and physician who was not part of the senior leadership ranks, as acting

director.

NIH scientists scrambled to look up Memoli’s scientific papers and how to pronounce his name, according to multiple staffers who spoke on the condition of anonymity because they were not authorized to provide details of events.

“All of us were on our computers trying to figure out who on Earth he was,” said a member of

the senior leadership team at one of NIH’s 27 separate institutes and centers.

That initial surprise presaged six weeks of upheaval for NIH’s scientific staff. The agency had long enjoyed bipartisan support and growing budgets, but with President Donald Trump’s return to power, it had lost its carefully protected distance from Washington’s partisan battles.

In just six weeks, the Trump administration overturned NIH’s leadership, slowed its main mission of identifying the best new science to fund and silenced personnel at the biggest sponsor of biomedical research in the world — a nearly \$48 billion enterprise that supports the work of some 300,000 external scientists.

“It’s terrible. It’s awful. People

SEE NIH ON A9

The Bowser dilemma: Toe or draw the line

BY PAUL SCHWARTZMAN, JENNY GATHRIGHT, MEAGAN FLYNN AND LAUREN LUMPKIN

As she ran for reelection a few years ago, D.C. Mayor Muriel E. Bowser’s campaign sent out thousands of fliers touting a moment that had catapulted her to national prominence.

“When Donald Trump attacked our values, Muriel Bowser stood tall,” declared the mass mailing, which showed the mayor looking out over Black Lives Matter Plaza, the two-block-long street mural she ordered painted outside the White House to defy President Donald Trump. “Our mayor showed the rest of the country what strong, proven leadership really looks like.”

The pose the mayor is striking these days is far less defiant.

Last week, after a congressional Republican threatened to slash highway funding because of the mural, Bowser (D) said she would paint over BLM Plaza’s bright yel-

low lettering, a display that had inspired praise from the likes of LeBron James and an invitation to address the 2020 Democratic National Convention.

Bowser’s about-face crystallized the often-measured, muted approach to Trump that she has assumed since the president returned to power and he and congressional Republicans have escalated threats to take over the city.

Unlike some Democratic leaders around the country, the mayor did not directly criticize Trump when he pardoned 1,600 Jan. 6 defendants, including those who attacked D.C. police officers. She no longer refers to D.C. as a “sanctuary city” — a term that provokes Republican ire — as she did after Trump was elected in 2016. Her administration even has removed references to the label from D.C.’s government website.

The mayor, who declined to be interviewed for this article, has told reporters she would not react to every Trump pronouncement,

SEE BOWSER ON A16

At Texas border, elected officials ditch Democrats

Blue counties are going red, signaling how much the region’s politics and Hispanic voters are changing



MATT MCCLAIN/THE WASHINGTON POST

“The Republicans have a great opportunity,” said Webb County Judge Tano Tijerina, who recently left the Democratic Party for the GOP. “There’s a lot of people like myself. ... You can change our minds.”

BY MOLLY HENNESSY-FISKE

LAREDO, TEXAS — Tano Tijerina spent a decade as the Democratic chief executive of Webb County here in South Texas. But when he was honored recently by the local chapter of the country’s oldest Hispanic civil rights organization, it was as a converted Republican touting a second Trump administration.

“Sometimes we need to break things down to build them up,” Tijerina declared to enthusiastic applause.

Democrats’ hold over Texas border counties is waning, with rising stars like Tijerina switching parties and GOP candidates flipping traditionally blue seats. Political experts credit the resurgence of Donald Trump, as well as a huge influx of campaign dollars, and foresee a lasting shift that could have major implications in coming years.

“The Republicans have a great opportunity,” Tijerina said in late

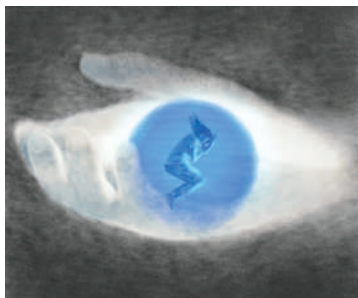
SEE TEXAS ON A12

METRO

The U-Va. board voted to end its DEI office. Other schools could follow.

SPORTS

The NBA is facing an analytics-fueled crisis — and MLB can relate.



BOOK WORLD

The imagined future of this vivid dystopian novel feels eerily on the mark.

BUSINESS

The truth about DOGE’s AI plans: The tech can’t do that, our critic writes.



ARTS & STYLE

Peter Wolf was one of rock’s wildest front men, until rock forgot him.

TRAVEL

All-day breakfast, no vodka: Poland’s milk bars are for everyone.

COMICS.....INSERT
OBITUARIES.....C4
OPINION PAGES.....A21
WORLD NEWS.....A18

CONTENT © 2025
The Washington Post / Year 148, No. 54150

